

There's always a chance with a used car that you're buying somebody else's problems. [Carfax.com](http://www.carfax.com) (www.carfax.com) will check its database of over 2 billion records and produce a report that reveals hidden problems that may affect the safety or resale value of the car. You may find that the car was turned in under the lemon law, salvaged after being totaled in an accident or flood, used as a taxi, or that the odometer was rolled back. To use this service, all you need is the vehicle identification number (VIN) of the car, usually found on a metal plate inside the windshield. The cost is \$24.99 for a single report or \$29.99 for unlimited reports for thirty days.

Trade In or Sell It Yourself?

You almost always come out ahead by selling your old car yourself. If you want to trade the car in, discuss the possibility only after you've already negotiated the best possible price for your new car. Tell the dealer that you'd rather just focus on buying a new car; that way, if you decide later to get a quote for a trade, you know there's no shuffling going on between the price of the new car and the trade-in amount.